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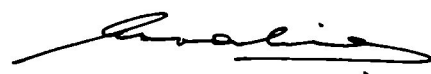
From the editor-in-chief

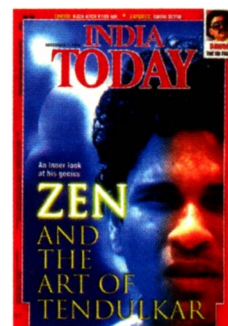
The longest-running cliché in Indian sport goes like this: 'If cricket is a religion, Sachin is God'. In India, cricket fans go to extremes when it comes to hype but shorn of blasphemy, if India has a sporting god, it can only be Sachin Ramesh Tendulkar. Now 36, Sachin's amazing career seems to carry on with no lessening of motivation, focus, talent and that elusive factor called genius. He featured in our '60 Greatest Indians' special issue in 2008 and ranked 23rd in this year's 'High & Mighty' issue, where we wrote: "In his 20th year in cricket, he is not only the sport's Peter Pan but also owns all the records that matter, most runs and most centuries, both in Tests and ODIs." Tendulkar is not just an outstanding Indian sportsman, he is a national icon, a role model and an inspiration for millions with his attitude to the game and his dignified, low-key profile off the field.

So much has been written on the man who is arguably the greatest cricketer the world has seen that it seemed almost overkill for us to think of another cover story on Sachin. Yet, he deserves no less. For two decades, he has defined true greatness and given all of us, not just cricket fans, the kind of moments when it's great to be an Indian. Sure, India has many sporting heroes: Dhyan Chand, Sunil Gavaskar, Prakash Padukone, Viswanathan Anand, to name a few. Sachin's records and consistency over two decades take him to another level. To complete 20 years in cricket is reason enough for us to celebrate the master by putting him on our cover for the sixth time, but only twice before has he been the sole focus.

Our intention this time was not just another recounting of his records and his career. Deputy Editor Sharda Ugra had spent hours with Sachin in Mumbai, getting him to look back on the last two decades, the secret to his durability and how he handles the pressures of being such a big star and still remain modest and ego-free. It is, in many ways, the definitive interview but for a definitive assessment of the man and his rightful place in cricketing history, we turned to Harsha Bhogle whose own career as cricket writer and commentator has run parallel to Sachin's. Bhogle's first assignment as a cub reporter was to report on a 14-year-old schoolboy prodigy who had just scored 1,028 runs in five innings, four of them not out. As Bhogle wrote for us in the '60 Greatest Indians' article: "I had a box seat at the Great Tendulkar Show; watching the transition from a shy, confident schoolboy to a shy, confident megastar. He's had a lot of fun in that journey but even he can, at best, hazard a guess at how much fun it has been for us, just watching the spectacle."

It's been a spectacle that has created a legend and we have tried to recapture some of that genius but also put him in personalised perspective and assign his place in sporting history.


(Aroon Purie)



OUR DECEMBER
1998 COVER